

STATE OF NEW YORK

7400--B

2025-2026 Regular Sessions

IN ASSEMBLY

March 25, 2025

Introduced by M. of A. EPSTEIN, CUNNINGHAM, VALDEZ, LEVENBERG, ALVAREZ, BURDICK -- read once and referred to the Committee on Higher Education -- committee discharged, bill amended, ordered reprinted as amended and recommitted to said committee -- committee discharged, bill amended, ordered reprinted as amended and recommitted to said committee

AN ACT to amend the education law, in relation to implementing a students' bill of rights for city university of New York institutions

The People of the State of New York, represented in Senate and Assembly, do enact as follows:

Section 1. The education law is amended by adding a new article 129-C to read as follows:

ARTICLE 129-C

IMPLEMENTATION BY COLLEGES AND UNIVERSITIES OF A STUDENTS' BILL OF RIGHTS

Section 6450. Students' bill of rights.

§ 6450. Students' bill of rights. 1. As used in this section, the following terms shall have the following meanings:

a. "Institution" shall mean any college or university in the city university of New York.

b. "School-sponsored media" means any material that is prepared, written, published, or broadcast by a student journalist at an institution, distributed or generally made available to members of the student body or the public. "School-sponsored media" shall not include media intended for distribution or transmission solely in the classroom in which the media is produced.

c. "Student journalist" means a student enrolled in an institution who gathers, compiles, writes, edits, photographs, records, or prepares information for dissemination in school-sponsored media.

EXPLANATION--Matter in italics (underscored) is new; matter in brackets [-] is old law to be omitted.

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1 d. "Student media advisor" means an individual employed, appointed, or
2 designated by an institution to supervise or provide instruction relat-
3 ing to school-sponsored media.

4 2. Every institution shall adopt written rules implementing this
5 section by amending its code of conduct or other comparable policies. A
6 copy of such rules and policies shall be provided by each institution to
7 all students enrolled in said institution using a method and manner
8 appropriate to its institutional culture. Each institution shall also
9 post such rules and policies on its website in an easily accessible
10 manner to the public.

11 3. Every institution shall adopt and implement the following
12 "Students' Bill of Rights":

13 a. (i) The elected student leader shall be able to message the student
14 body through e-mail, or a substantially equivalent system utilized by
15 the institution to communicate with the student body, with prior
16 approval from the campus office of student life to ensure that the
17 communication with students complies with federal, state and local law,
18 and institution policies. Such prior approval shall be made in a timely
19 and efficient manner. Any denial of part of or an entire communication
20 shall be made in writing with a citation to the provision of law or
21 institution policy which would be violated by such communication.

22 (ii) No expression made by an elected student leader which is
23 protected by this paragraph shall be deemed to be an expression of poli-
24 cy, opinion or position of the institution, nor shall any such
25 expression be considered to be an endorsement in any way by the institu-
26 tion and no institution, employee, parent, legal guardian or administra-
27 tor of an institution shall be held liable in any civil or criminal
28 action for any expression made by an elected student leader, except in
29 cases of willful or wanton misconduct. Nothing in this paragraph shall
30 be construed to create any private action on behalf of a student other
31 than to seek injunctive relief allowing the messaging or communication
32 in question.

33 b. All student conduct cases shall have student participation on the
34 body judging student conduct.

35 c. All institution policy-making bodies shall have student represen-
36 tation on such body in policy-making roles for any policy affecting
37 students.

38 d. All students shall have access to designated student free speech
39 spaces on campus.

40 e. (i) A student journalist shall have the right to exercise free
41 speech and of the press in institution-sponsored media, regardless of
42 whether the media is supported financially by the institution or by use
43 of the facilities of an institution or produced in conjunction with a
44 class in which the student is enrolled.

45 (ii) A student journalist shall be responsible for determining the
46 news, opinion, and feature content of school-sponsored media.

47 (iii) There shall be no prior restraint of material prepared for offi-
48 cial publications of an institution except for the material described in
49 subparagraph (vi) of this paragraph.

50 (iv) No student media advisor or employee shall be dismissed,
51 suspended, disciplined, reassigned, transferred, or otherwise retaliated
52 against solely for acting to protect a pupil engaged in the conduct
53 authorized under this paragraph; and further no student media advisor or
54 employee shall be dismissed, suspended, disciplined, reassigned, trans-
55 ferred or otherwise retaliated against solely for an action, undertaken

1 in good faith with this paragraph, which results in the prohibition of
2 the publication of speech pursuant to this paragraph.

3 (v) Nothing in this paragraph shall preclude a student media advisor
4 from teaching professional standards of English and journalism to
5 student journalists or from grading the performance of a student in
6 accordance with such standards.

7 (vi) To the extent that an institution administrator chooses to engage
8 in pre-publication review, the following forms of expression shall not
9 be protected by this article:

10 (1) Expression that is libelous, slanderous or obscene;

11 (2) Expression that constitutes an unwarranted invasion of privacy;

12 (3) Expression that violates federal, state or local law; or

13 (4) Expression that incites students to commit an unlawful act where
14 such unlawful act would be both imminent and likely to occur, to violate
15 the policies of the institution, or to materially and substantially
16 disrupt the orderly operation of such institution.

17 (vii) No expression made by students in the exercise of free speech or
18 freedom of the press protected by this paragraph shall be deemed to be
19 an expression of policy, opinion or position of the institution, nor
20 shall any such expression be considered to be an endorsement in any way
21 by the institution and no institution, student media advisor, employee,
22 parent, legal guardian or administrator of an institution shall be held
23 liable in any civil or criminal action for any expression made or
24 published by students, except in cases of willful or wanton misconduct.
25 Nothing in this paragraph shall be construed to create any private
26 action on behalf of a student other than to seek injunctive relief
27 allowing the publication of the speech in question.

28 (viii) Political expression by students in school-sponsored media
29 shall not be deemed the use of public funds for political purposes.

30 f. The elected student government shall decide how funds from student
31 activity fees are allocated. Where an institution does not have an
32 elected student government, such institution shall develop a process to
33 allow for the student body to determine how student activity fees are
34 allocated. An institution shall not block a student activity fee funding
35 allocation decision made pursuant to this paragraph as long as such
36 allocation conforms with the student activity fee policies of the insti-
37 tution.

38 § 2. This act shall take effect on the first of July next succeeding
39 the date on which it shall have become a law.